high-twenties in every national poll. The party had its first wins in the parliamentary constituencies in Bidar on the state's northernmost tip, Mangalore on its southern coastline, Tumkur in the south and Bangalore South in the state capital. It won each of these seats by large margins (with over 40 per cent of the votes in each constituency) and steadily used these areas as a base to expand its footprint outwards. Each of these seats was also representative of the early social coalition that the party was creating in Karnataka.

In Bidar, the party won because of Ram Chandra Veerappa, a Dalit farmer leader who was known as a 'progressive nationalist' in the constituency. 'We won on his shoulders,' says Lehar Singh.[72] He represented the party's social push with farmers. Yediyurappa himself was a farmer leader who had won his first assembly election from Shikaripura after going on Cycle Yatras.[73] Tumkur, the seat of the Siddaganga shrine, came to the party because of S. Mallikarjunaiah, a Lingayat leader.[74] He represented the Lingayat base that the party would subsequently build under Yediyurappa. The party has never lost Bangalore South, a seat first won by the late Ananth Kumar, since 1991. It represents the urban constituency that the party was beginning to appeal to. Yediyurappa and Ananth Kumar were later to become the twin engines of the BJP's growth.

Mangalore, on the coast, is symbolic of Hindutva's increasing acceptability in the state. In the 1940s and '50s, the Sangh set up its first Karnataka shakhas along the coast. The coastal areas also had a large Muslim population, were prosperous, and were home to Saraswat Brahmins from Maharashtra and Goa. Mangalore has often seen communal flare-ups and these tensions mean that even inadvertent accidents could take on a communal colour there. The suspicion of cow slaughter was among the most common flashpoints for such flare-ups. As a former senior police office recounted, 'There was a typical example of a van which people suspected of carrying cows. It wasn't, but the driver panicked and sped up to escape those chasing him. While speeding like this, he ended up hitting a person from that community purely by accident and this became a big communal riot.'[75] By 1996, the party expanded further along the coastline, adding the seats of Dharwad North and Kanara. It